

A Commentary on 3 John
Stephen L. Brown

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Dedicated to Dave and Lynn Hockaday and Brian and Victoria Rice, missionaries who welcomed me into their homes

The Book of 3 John

Below is the book of 3 John, as rendered in the Text-Critical English New Testament (available online at ebible.org). Note that this translation reflects the systematic Greek distinction between singular and plural pronouns: the word “you,” when spelled with an inwardly-curving *υ*, refers to just one person (as, for example, in the second verse); regularly spelled “you” refers to multiple people.

1 The elder to the beloved Gaius, whom I love in the truth.

2 Beloved, I pray that in all respects you may prosper and be in good health, even as your soul prospers. **3** For I was overjoyed when the brothers came and testified about your faithfulness to the truth and how you walk in the truth. **4** I have no greater joy than to hear that my children are walking in the truth.

5 Beloved, you are acting faithfully in whatever you do for the brothers and for those who are strangers to you. **6** They have testified of your love before the church, and you will do well to send them on their way in a manner worthy of God. **7** For they went out for the sake of the Name, receiving nothing from the Gentiles. **8** Therefore we ought to receive men like them, so that we may be fellow workers for the truth.

9 I wrote to the church, but Diotrephes, who loves to put himself first, does not acknowledge us. **10** So if I come, I will call attention to what he is doing and the evil accusations of nonsense that he is making against us. And he is not satisfied with that! He not only refuses to receive the brothers, but also stops those who want to do so and throws them out of the church.

11 Beloved, do not imitate what is evil, but what is good. Whoever does good is of God; whoever does evil has not seen God. **12** Demetrius is well spoken of by everyone—and even by the truth itself. We also speak well of him, and you know that our testimony is true.

13 I have much to write, but I do not want to write to you with pen and ink. 14 I hope to see you soon, and we will speak face to face.

15 Peace be with you. The friends greet you. Greet the friends by name.

Authorship

The author identifies himself only as “the elder” (v1)—quite sufficient in a day when letters were normally handed off personally by someone known to both the sender and the recipient who could identify who this man¹ was, but obviously not tremendously informative for us today. But a bit of sleuthing seems to reveal his identity: the vocabulary, turns of phrase, and pacing of this letter is so similar to the gospel of John that by far the most reasonable inference is that the same man wrote all four of these books.² To be sure, matters of style are somewhat subjective, and some scholars have doubted the connection, but the similarities outweigh the differences—and that by a wide margin.³ And since it is all but certain that the apostle John, the brother of James, wrote the fourth gospel,⁴ it is all but certain that the same man wrote 3 John, together with the other two epistles that are so similar.

Recipients

Again, with the way that letters were passed along in the ancient Roman world, it would have been clear who this letter was for. We only know that his name is Gaius—an extremely common gentile name at the time. He is loved by John (v1), well spoken of by mutual friends (v3), and clearly active in his church (vv5-6). The fact that Gaius is not directed to take direct action, but to wait for John’s arrival, argues that Gaius is not a leader in the church. Perhaps he is a deacon, but this is little more than a guess.

Where is Gaius’ church? Credible church tradition locates the apostle John in Ephesus in his later years. If so, he is writing to a church elsewhere, but apparently also a church known to him

¹ In Greek, “elder” is masculine.

² The book of Revelation is another matter: this book, especially when read in its original Greek, is arguably quite different. The present commentary on 3 John will not take a position one way or another on who wrote Revelation.

³ Contrast the situation in, say, 1 Peter as compared to 2 Peter; and to a lesser extent in Romans as compared to 1 Timothy.

⁴ The apostle John—fairly prominent in Matthew, Mark, Luke, and Acts—is conspicuously absent from John, while the circumlocution “the disciple whom Jesus loved” shows up repeatedly. Based on 21:2, this disciple must have been a son of Zebedee, either James or John. Since James died early in the Church’s history (Ac 12:2), the author must have been John. He made his identity tricky to uncover either by way of playfulness or, as I suspect, of humility—unwilling to refer to himself by name in writing about Jesus Christ, yet unable to leave unmentioned his awe at God’s love for him.

(vv9) and to which he hopes to travel in the not-too-distant future (vv10, 14). The names that occur in this letter—Gaius, Diotrephes, and Demetrius—are all names (Latin in the first case, Greek in the other two cases) either of gentile men or of Jewish men quite comfortable with gentile culture. All in all, it is a reasonable guess that the church was somewhere in Anatolia.⁵

Occasion

What prompted this letter? Possibly John decided to write this letter upon hearing about Gaius from some mutual friends, friends who in any case told the apostle about Gaius' good deeds (v3). Perhaps John knew, or suspected, that Gaius was discouraged; certainly, John goes out of his way to encourage him (vv4-6a). Possibly, Gaius was perplexed at Diotrephes' vitriol, such that the apostle felt the need to affirm and to justify Gaius' actions (vv6a-8). In any case, Gaius' church is facing heated controversy over certain Christians who are passing through—are they to be supported or shunned? John writes to help Gaius understand how to think about the situation and to encourage him to continue in his work. He might also be preparing his friend for an unpleasant event—the apostle aims sooner or later to come to the church and publicly confront Diotrephes.

Verse One

The term “elder” (πρεσβυτερος) is a flexible one, referring to an old man, a respected man, a Jewish leader, a church leader, or some combination of these and related ideas. If, as seems most likely, the apostle John is the writer, it is notable that he feels no need to highlight his authority by using the word “apostle.” But he does go out of the way to highlight his love for Gaius, calling him “beloved,” and underscoring his love as being “in truth.”⁶

Verse Two

John regularly prays for Gaius' outward well-being; he is confident, for reasons he will explain in the next verse, in Gaius' spiritual well-being.

Verse Three

Certain Christians—evidently friends of both Gaius and of John—have made their way to John, and they have told the apostle of the fruit of the Spirit evident in Gaius' life. We can reasonably infer that they also informed John of the troubling events at the church there. They might have made the

⁵ This is, more or less the modern country of Türkiye.

⁶ John does not add a “grace and peace” greeting in the style of Paul or Peter; as meaningful as those greetings are, he feels no need to use this language just because those apostles do. God has given to each individual a personality and style. There is no need to be submerged in any outside trend.

journey to Ephesus specifically to speak with the apostle about these things. In any case, they have much to say about how Gaius is living for the Lord (“walk[ing] in the truth”).

John often seems to use the word “truth” as a shorthand for Christianity, with all of its centering of Christ and transformation of morals (most clearly so in 1 Jn 3:19, 2 Jn 2). The connection between the concept of truth and the totality of Christianity is a compelling one: the claims made in Scripture about Christ are factually accurate (truth as opposed to error or falsity), and the claims made on us in Scripture are morally upright (truth as opposed to deceit or delusion).

Verse Four

Paul expresses the same thought in 1 Thes 2:19-20, 3:6-8. John loves to call Christians associated with him “children” (doing so about a dozen times in the five chapters of his first epistle). This is a term of affection (cf. Jn 13:33, 21:5).

Verses Five and Six

Here John segues into the main part of his letter. He needs Gaius to understand that he has been doing the right thing in welcoming and assisting certain traveling Christians. Evidently, some Christians⁷ have been passing through on some mission for the Lord (as v7 will show), and need some level of hospitality and support for some period of time.⁸ Often, apparently, these are not people Gaius was personally familiar with.⁹ And some of them have come to John’s church and related how Gaius had helped them. John approves of Gaius’ hospitality toward them, and urges him to continue in this with all diligence (“worthy of God”). Travel in the ancient world was difficult and often dangerous, yet John is calling for more than mere room and board; the apostle describes and commends a radical generosity.¹⁰

⁷ Whether the Christians in question are only men or a mix of men and women is not clear. In Greek, the term *αδελφους* is used—this term can mean “brothers” or “siblings.”

⁸ A plausible guess is that these people are evangelists (cf. Ac 21:8, Eph 4:11, 2 Tim 4:5).

⁹ The manuscripts of 3 John are somewhat divergent concerning the last few words of v5. Most read “for the brothers and for those who are strangers to you,” while others read “for the brothers who are strangers to you” or (as an alternative translation of the same Greek) “for the brothers, especially when they are unknown to you.” These two basic possibilities are not as different from each other in Greek as they might seem to be in English—the Greek runs either *εις τους αδελφους και εις τους ξενους* or *εις τους αδελφους και τουτο ξενους*. Clearly, the visual similarity of these forms, together with the plausibility of either reading, lies behind the error. The meaning differs little.

¹⁰ At the risk of diluting the urgency with which this last statement is to be read, it does seem worth mentioning that “to send them on their way” is not necessarily exactly the same as saying that the congregation should underwrite their expenses in the long run (particularly, one might further mention, if doing so would inhibit a congregation’s ability to give a living wage to its own

Verse Seven

Why are these Christians to be so diligently supported? First, they are doing what they are doing for the sake of Christ—"the name" being a way of referring to the name above every name, the name of Jesus, our Lord and our God (cf. Gen 32:29, Lev 24:11, Mat 10:22, 18:20, Jn 14:26, Ac 4:12, 9:15, Phil 2:9).

Second, they do not accept assistance from non-Christians ("the Gentiles").¹¹ Outside the city of Rome itself, the Roman empire did not make it a regular practice to assist its citizens with vouchers for food, direct assistance to their bank accounts, or anything comparable, so John does not have things of that nature in mind. Instead, he must be referring to the ancient practice of making donations toward supposed holy men or traveling philosophers and teachers. The Christians John is commending are following the principle spoken of by Jesus in Mat 10:8—the Gospel is not for sale, nor must it seem to be so. Therefore, to the extent that Christians traveling with the message of Jesus need financial support, it should not come from those who need the gospel, but from those who have already received the gospel.

Verse Eight

In light of what has been said in the following verse, it is evident that it is a worthy cause to assist¹² these Christians in their work, and that, in a very real sense, their work becomes our work when we send them on their way in a manner worthy of God.

Verse Nine

John notes that he had written a letter to the church,¹³ "but Diotrephes... does not acknowledge us." Possibly John is reminding Gaius of this incident, but, especially in light of the following verse

elders—cf. 1 Cor 9:4-11, 1 Tim 5:17-18). The New Testament does not give the Church a developed framework for the logistics of evangelism across great distances. It certainly does not forbid the existence and work of missions agencies and the like, but we should be careful not to read modern institutions and practices back into the pages of the New Testament.

¹¹ It is striking that John uses this term to refer to unbelievers, for originally it would have meant non-Jews, but—writing, as it seems, primarily to non-Jews and in a time when globally the Church was less and less thoroughly Jewish in its membership and outlook—now refers to those who have not accepted the gospel of Jesus Christ. John is fully onboard with the idea expressed in 1 Pet 2:9.

¹² The Greek manuscripts vary between "receive" and "support," these two words differing in Greek by only a single letter. In this context, the general drift is the same either way.

¹³ I do not think that the content either of 1 John or of 2 John fits well enough with the situation here to suppose that one of those letters was what John wrote to this church. The letter that John sent to Diotrephes is lost to history.

(“I will call attention to what he is doing”), it seems likely that Diotrephes has suppressed the fact that John even wrote a letter. While some conversations—or at least sensitive details in those conversations—will need to be kept private, it is a troubling sign when a leader or an institution goes out of its way to control the flow of information, keeping people in the dark.

In mentioning this letter and its poor reception on the part of Diotrephes, John is preparing Gaius for the public rebuke that will sooner or later come Diotrephes’ way. Diotrephes’ disregard for the letter is disregard for John. Now, it is not certain whether by the words “does not acknowledge us” John means to say that Diotrephes is ignoring both him and a wider circle of church leaders, or whether “us” here is—as was somewhat conventional in ancient Greek letter-writing—another way of saying “me.” The facts that this verse begins “I wrote” and that the next verse says “if I come” suggest that the second interpretation of “us” is better.

Diotrephes’ disregard for the apostle’s letter stems from his inflated sense of self-importance. From the authority Diotrephes is assumed to have in this verse, and from the authority he is described as wielding in the following verse, it is apparent that Diotrephes is a pastor, or otherwise a man in authority. Jesus’ instructions are that leaders should have humble attitudes (Mat 20:25ff). Sad to say, not everyone who is, or claims to be, a Christian actually follows these instructions. The decisions of Christian leadership are not automatically correct.

Verse Ten

For some reason, John is unsure whether he can come in-person soon (“if I come”), though he hopes to (v14). But whenever he can come, he will take the opportunity to call out Diotrephes, bringing to the church’s attention Diotrephes’ sins.¹⁴ Diotrephes has been slandering the apostle, falsely accusing him of doing evil things. He has also been mistreating certain church members, expelling them from the church if they refuse his directive to shun the traveling Christians.

Has Gaius been kicked out of the church by Diotrephes? On the one hand, he is known for helping the brothers (vv5-6). On the other hand, John tells Gaius to pass along greetings to his friends (v14), and, the way v10 is worded, it is not clear whether Gaius was among those expelled. Gaius continues to be closely associated with the church in any event. Perhaps Gaius is a deacon, and Diotrephes feels banning him would be a bridge too far for the congregation. If Gaius has been expelled, John’s commendation will surely be enough to reinstate him when he comes.

¹⁴ The implication seems to me that Diotrephes will be removed from his position, but this is not completely clear—at least a stern rebuke his coming his way, and then removal if repentance is not forthcoming (cf. Mat 18:15-18, 1 Tim 5:20). Also debatable is the basis on which either rebuke or removal will proceed: is John, not a part of Diotrephes’ congregation, empowered to do this only because he is an apostle, or are we to see here an example of accountability across, and not only within, local churches?

Verse Eleven

The Church is full of both good and bad examples. The following verse will supply the name of a man to emulate; this verse points out in no uncertain terms that Diotrephes is a man whose example is of a life not to imitate.

This whole situation brings to John's mind a principle (one that he develops at greater length in 1 John): those who have truly absorbed the message of Christ will demonstrate it by their good works, while those who have not come to know Jesus personally will sooner or later betray this ignorance of the Lord by their evil deeds.

Verse Twelve

While Diotrephes is the kind of man not to imitate, Demetrius is the kind of man to follow. Perhaps Demetrius is the man bringing the present letter (what we call 3 John) to Gaius, or perhaps he is one of the traveling Christians or a pending replacement for Diotrephes. In any case, he is, John says, affirmed by "everyone" (whether he means everyone in his local church or the Church at large to whatever extent it has had opportunity to meet him, clearly Demetrius has found wide acceptance among the faithful) and even "by the truth itself" (a striking phrase that seems to mean that he matches exactly what it means to be a Christian; cf. on v3 above, second paragraph). Furthermore, John, using his unique blend of anonymity and emphasis (cf. Jn 19:35, 21:24), adds his own (cf. on v9, second paragraph) affirmation of Demetrius' character.¹⁵

Verses Thirteen and Fourteen

In what appears to be his standard approach to things (cf. 2 Jn 12), John prefers not to attempt to delve into great detail in letter form, instead planning to speak with Gaius in-person. This, it seems to me, establishes a model to be followed in our own day: technology for long-distance communication (letters for John; that and email, texting, videoconferencing, and the like for us) is very useful, but a high value is still to be placed on face to face interaction.

Verse Fifteen

¹⁵ When John says "you know," there is disagreement in the manuscripts as to whether the apostle is speaking to Gaius specifically (οἶδας), or whether he is including Gaius' friends in the statement (οἶδατε). It seems more likely that a few scribes would accidentally (or deliberately, out of a misplaced desire to fix the supposed mistakes of their scribal predecessors) conform the verb to the grammatical singular of the bulk of this letter than that the majority of scribes would suddenly introduce a plural.

Face to face interaction is not always possible, and so John not only pronounces a benediction of peace on Gaius, but also passes on greetings from those with him. He also asks Gaius to greet others on his behalf. In Christianity, friendliness is a core value.

Some Reflections on 3 John

John is neither unrealistic about the potentiality of poor leaders in the Church, nor jaded by the actuality of their presence there. Gaius, for his part, has not rushed to desert his local church at the first sign of trouble, nor has John in any way implied that he should do so.

Even those doing the right thing already can benefit from encouragement and affirmation.

One of the ways to spread the gospel is to support the gospel-spreaders: hospitality toward those who have gone out for the sake of the name enables and encourages the work of God.

Friendship in Christ loves being face-to-face; but until that is possible, prayers, letters, and greetings to and from other friends can sustain it. Likewise, we pray, read the Bible, and fellowship with Christians until the day we see Jesus face to face.